

Financially, 1999 was the best year of my career. But on the personal front, I had to endure a huge loss. Bauji's condition started worsening around September. Finally the end drew near, and the tests showed that now there was no delaying the Grim Reaper who had been repulsed for the last twelve months.

I asked the doctor if Bauji's last days would be painful.

'Yes, they will be. The growth has completely taken over his lungs. He will cough his way to death, spitting blood,' he said.

When I heard the doctor's verdict, I cursed myself. It would have been better if I had let Bauji die when he had just two weeks to live. I had spent money on prolonging his life, only to see him die a painful death. I really wished the growth in his brain had continued at its normal pace and granted him a painless exit. As I was lost in my thoughts that evening in office, Bina called, saying Bauji was acting strangely. He was not recognizing people and was indifferent to everybody around. The next day, I took him to the doctor for a check-up. The doctor said the growth in his brain had resumed, and that it was now a matter of days. Two days later, Bauji lapsed into a coma from which he never recovered.